

What else to watch: *The Bicycle Thief* (1948, pp.94–97) ■ *L'Avventura* (1960) ■ *Juliet of the Spirits* (1965) ■ *Amarcord* (1973) ■ *Cinema Paradiso* (1988) ■ *Celebrity* (1998) ■ *Lost in Translation* (2003)

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All art is autobiographical.

The pearl is the
oyster's autobiography.

Federico Fellini

The Atlantic, 1965

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seven dawns. If you look hard enough, you'll also find that it contains the seven deadly sins and allusions to the biblical story of the seven days it took God to make the world. Religion is core to Fellini's work. When the movie's hero, a nocturnal journalist named Marcello Rubini (Marcello Mastroianni), falls for the beautiful movie star Sylvia (Anita Ekberg), he tells her, "You are the first woman on the first day of Creation. You are mother, sister, lover, friend, angel, devil, earth, home."

It's up to the viewer to decide on the significance of *La Dolce Vita*'s religious overtones and apparent obsession with the number seven. What is more certain is that the movie is concerned with the nature of men's relationship with women. Marcello spends his nights on Via Veneto, 1950s Rome's street of nightclubs, sidewalk

cafés, and after-dark debauchery, searching for happiness in the shape of an idealized love. There are several contenders, including his suicidal fiancée, Emma (Yvonne Furneaux), and the mysterious Maddalena (Anouk Aimée). But it's not until Ekberg's Sylvia arrives in the city, amid a riot of adulation

and publicity, that Marcello glimpses perfection. In the movie's most celebrated scene, Sylvia wanders into the waters of the Trevi Fountain after a long, carnivalesque night on the town. She calls to Marcello to follow her in, and the viewer sees Sylvia through Marcello's eyes: the ideal »

Marcello (Marcello Mastroianni)

is smitten with Sylvia, but they can only spend one night together.

